ing to the 2023 'Global Burden of Disease' (GBD) study by the Seattle-based Institute for Health Metrics and Evaluation, low back pain ranks among the top 10 leading causes of early death and disability worldwide. In the 2021 edition of the same study, which provides the most up-to-date national estimates, India accounted for 15 per cent of all spinal injuries globally—the second-highest after China. More recently, a 2025 epidemiological study published on ResearchGate estimated that 1.5 million Indians are living with disabilities caused by spinal injuries.

Yet, for all the bleak statistics, spine care is at a crossroads. A wave of innovation—from minimally invasive surgery and robotics to regenerative therapies—is offering patients faster recovery, less pain and, in some cases, the chance to avoid surgery altogether. Complementing these cutting-edge advances are yoga-based interventions and other holistic practices rooted in traditional knowledge, which are helping patients build strength, improve flexibility and support long-term spine health. What was once a life sentence of chronic discomfort is increasingly becoming a condition that can be managed, and sometimes reversed.

CATCHING THEM YOUNG

Our ability to walk upright—a defining trait of being human—came at a cost. As humans evolved from moving on four limbs to two, the spine curved into an S-shape, freeing our hands but exposing the body to new mechanical stresses. This evolutionary trade-off made the spine biologically vulnerable to wear and tear with age. Modern lifestyles are accelerating that natural decline. While spinal trauma can occur anywhere from the neck down to the tailbone, it is the lower back that remains the most common trouble spot.

"Physical neglect and mental stress are creating a generation prone to spinal dysfunction far earlier than ever. Many delay seeking help, letting small, fixable problems turn chronic"

DR ISSAC MATHAI
Founder, Soukya, a holistic health centre in Bengaluru

The World Health Organization notes that back pain is already the leading cause of disability worldwide, and is projected to afflict 843 million people globally by 2050, up from 619 million in 2020, with Asia carrying the sharpest burden. The stakes are high. For, young adults with persistent back pain have a 60 per cent chance of developing chronic spinal problems by 40, warns Dr Vidyadhara S., chairman and head of spine surgery at Manipal Hospitals, Old Airport Road, Bengaluru. "Spinal deformities in youth can accelerate disc degeneration, trigger premature arthritis, chronic pain, even respiratory or neurological issues," he adds.

ANATOMY OF STRAIN

WHAT PART OF YOUR SPINE IS UNDER PRESSURE AND WHY

CERVICAL SPINE (NECK)

Posture: Forward head tilt from prolonged screen use (tech neck) compresses spinal discs, strains muscles

Stress: Keeps neck and shoulder muscles in constant tension, reducing mobility

THORACIC SPINE (UPPER & MID-BACK)

Less movement: Sedentary habits stiffen the rib-to-spine joints, affecting breathing and posture

Muscle weakness: Weak upper back muscles lead to rounded shoulders and hunched posture

LUMBAR SPINE (LOWER BACK)

Obesity: Extra weight overloads lumbar discs and joints, accelerating wear and tear

Wrong exercise: Sudden high-impact or unsupervised lifting can cause strains, disc bulges or herniation

SACRAL REGION & PELVIS

Posture & weak core: Poor pelvic alignment and weak abdominal muscles shift extra pressure to lower spine and hips, affecting balance

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